

THE MEANING OF ORAKZAI

LOST → JOURNEY → HOME → IDENTITY → FUTURE

ORAKZAI

“Lost Son”

A name can carry a story.

The name “Orakzai” is commonly associated with the Pashto expression “Wrak Zoy” or related historical spellings, traditionally understood as “lost son.”¹ The phrase has become closely connected with one of the best-known origin traditions of the Orakzai people.

According to this tradition, an ancestral figure named Sikandar Shah was an exiled or lost prince who eventually reached the region of Tirah.² The story says that he settled there and that his descendants became associated with the name Orakzai — the “lost son” and, by extension, the descendants of the lost son.

This story has been repeated in historical and ethnographic accounts of the tribe, although details vary between sources. It is therefore important to distinguish between the meaning traditionally attributed to the name and the question of whether every detail of the origin story can be historically verified.

THE WORD

Historical sources use different spellings when rendering the name and its supposed Pashto components into English. The variation in spelling reflects the difficulty of representing Pashto words in English using different historical systems of transliteration.³

Wrak Zoy

Wrak Dzoy

Wrakzai

Orakzai

The central traditional interpretation remains connected with the idea of a “lost son.”

THE LEGEND OF THE LOST SON

The story of the lost son is more than an explanation of a tribal name. It is also a story about movement, exile, belonging, settlement, and the creation of a new home. In the traditional account, Sikandar Shah's journey eventually leads toward Tirah, a region deeply associated with Orakzai history and identity.⁴

The story describes a person who was separated from his original home and became connected to another land. That idea gives the name a powerful cultural resonance:

A lost son can find a home.

A displaced person can establish a new beginning.

A journey can become an ancestry.

And a name can preserve the memory of that journey.

HISTORY AND TRADITION

The story should nevertheless be read carefully. Tribal origin traditions are often preserved through oral history, genealogical narratives, and later written accounts. Such traditions can be culturally important without every element being independently verifiable through contemporary historical records.

For this reason, this book distinguishes between documented history, historical interpretation, oral tradition, genealogical tradition, and cultural memory. The “lost son” explanation belongs primarily to the traditional account of the name and should be presented with that context.

ORAKZAI AS IDENTITY

Whatever the precise historical path by which the name developed, “Orakzai” has become the name of a distinct Pashtun tribal community associated historically with Tirah and the surrounding region.⁵ For generations, the name has carried connections to family, territory, language, community, memory, and belonging.

Today, Orakzai identity exists far beyond one geographical location. Orakzais live in villages and towns, in major Pakistani cities, and in communities across the world. Geography can change, and identity can evolve, but a name can continue carrying memory across generations.

THE LOST SON — THE MODERN GENERATION

For me, the meaning of “lost son” carries a different significance in the modern world. It reminds me that identity is not only about where someone is standing today. It is also about remembering where the journey began.

The mountains may be far away, the cities may be different, and the technology may be new, but the connection to one's roots can remain. Perhaps that is why the phrase “lost son” feels so powerful. A lost son is not necessarily a son without a home. Sometimes, he is someone whose journey took him somewhere new — while the memory of where he came from remained with him.

“I’m Orakzai” begins with that memory.

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

For me, “Orakzai” is more than a surname or tribal designation. It is a connection to a history that deserves to be studied, questioned, documented, and passed forward responsibly. The story of the lost son is one part of that history. The generations that came after him are another. And the generations still to come will write the next part.

The expression “lost son” is a traditional explanation of the name Orakzai recorded in historical and modern accounts. Spellings and interpretations vary across sources. The associated story of Sikandar Shah is presented in this book as an origin tradition rather than as independently established genealogy.

1. Haroon Rashid, History of the Pathans (Vol. IV), p. 52.
2. L. W. King, The Orakzai Country and Clans (Lahore, 1900).
3. H. G. Raverty, Notes on Afghanistan and Part of Baluchistan (1888).
4. Encyclopaedia Britannica, 11th Edition (1911), entry on Orakzai.
5. Imperial Gazetteer of India, Provincial series: North-West-Frontier, p. 235.